SurveyMonkey

REPORT

State of Surveys 2024



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INTRODUCTION

The state of surveys for 2024

What happens in surveys reflects the real world

Sometimes the questions people ask can tell you as much as their answers. That's often the case with surveys—and there's a lot to learn from the 17 million active users asking 20 million questions on the SurveyMonkey platform every day. The survey questions people ask uncover the problems that companies are trying to solve, the challenges customers need help with, and insights into the daily decisions of consumers and business people.

For this report, we anonymized and aggregated 11 years worth of data and combed through it, looking for trends, patterns, and anomalies. Our goal was to use this data to better understand the issues of today and uncover nuances about how people are creating and taking surveys in the modern era.

Here are some of the things we hoped to learn:

- What are trending topics in surveys, and how can they help us understand our differences and similarities and how our views change over time?
- How are people changing their surveys to keep up with changing times?
- What principles of modern survey design catch people's attention and elicit the most thoughtful responses?

How survey data reveals social, cultural, and workplace shifts

When using surveys to study social issues, we often look at respondents' answers to try to understand their beliefs and values. But analyzing the questions asked in the surveys can give you hints about how people actually live those values.

For example, as societies develop a more nuanced understanding of gender inclusion, their surveys have developed as well. Many surveys contain demographic questions that ask respondents for their gender. In the past, binary answer options—male or female—were the standard. But today, it's considered a gender-inclusive best practice to offer more than two answer options to allow nonbinary respondents to identify themselves more accurately.

We looked at the number of surveys that include gender questions with more than two answer options on our platform on a global basis this year. In the US, we found that nearly 3 in 4 surveys that contain a gender question include three or more gender options, a growth of 9 percentage points (points) since last year.

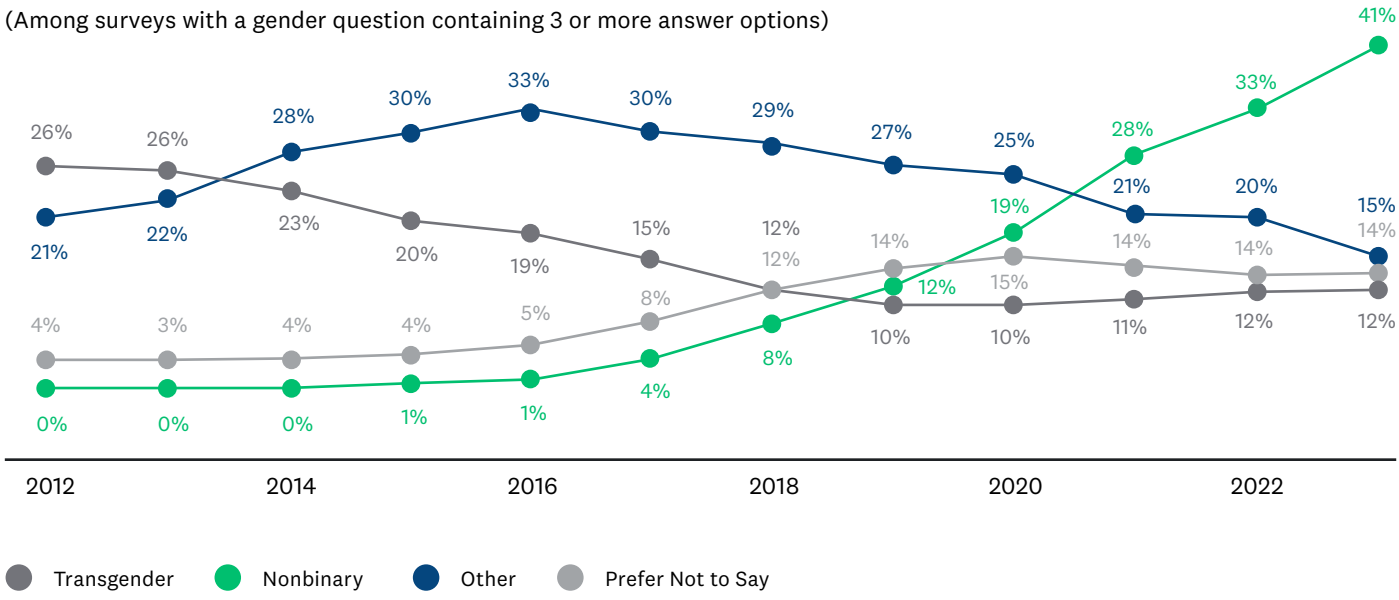


Nonbinary usage continues to rise in the US

“Other” also continues to decline, while the usage of “transgender” and “prefer not to say” remains stable

Gender Answer Options (US)

(Among surveys with a gender question containing 3 or more answer options)



This is a significant increase year over year, and supports the fact that gender inclusion is becoming mainstream in the US. You can see how gender inclusion is evolving in the rest of the world in chapter 2 of our report.

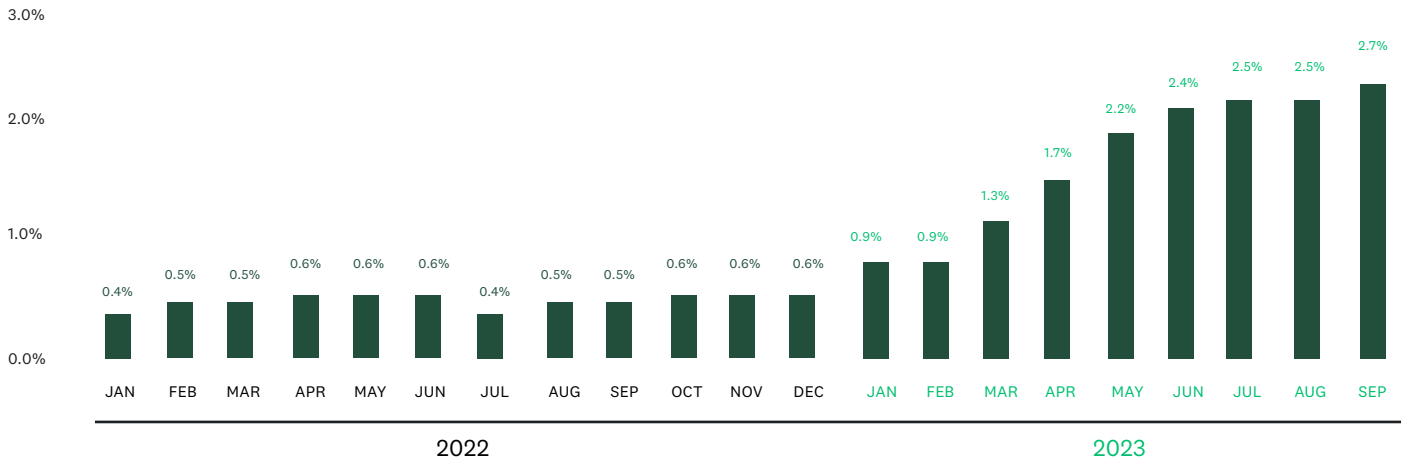
In another example of how survey questions can reveal what’s top of mind, we looked at AI. We knew AI had become a hot topic based on our own studies, as well as the daily headlines and heightened awareness on social media. So we dug into the topic by tracking the mentions of AI in the surveys that were launched on our platform.

We found that mentions of AI-related terms increase by 4x in 2023, following the introduction of ChatGPT in November 2022. You can read more about our AI findings in chapter 1 of this report.

Mentions of AI-related terms increase 4x in 2023, following the introduction of ChatGPT

By September 2023, nearly three percent (2.7%) of all surveys fielded on the SurveyMonkey platform contained some mention of AI-related terminology.

In November '22, OpenAI released its generative AI chatbot, ChatGPT



There's a lot more that our survey data revealed about what's trending and how people are thinking about the issues of the day. We've focused on gender inclusion, AI, and workplace/personal trends in the first three chapters of this report.

In addition, the data captured on our platform provides helpful clarity on how to get the best results from your survey initiatives. We tracked metrics like response submissions and completion rates and uncovered some key insights on the most successful methods.

Read on to learn about the questions and answers that millions of people are asking—and answering—every day.

CHAPTER 1

The rise of AI

If it feels like AI has taken over the airwaves, our survey platform showed evidence of its meteoric rise. In previous years, AI was mentioned in surveys 0.2% of the time. Mentions doubled in 2022, hovering around 0.5% or 0.6%. By September of 2023, mentions of AI in surveys increased to nearly 3% (2.7%)—a 4x increase.

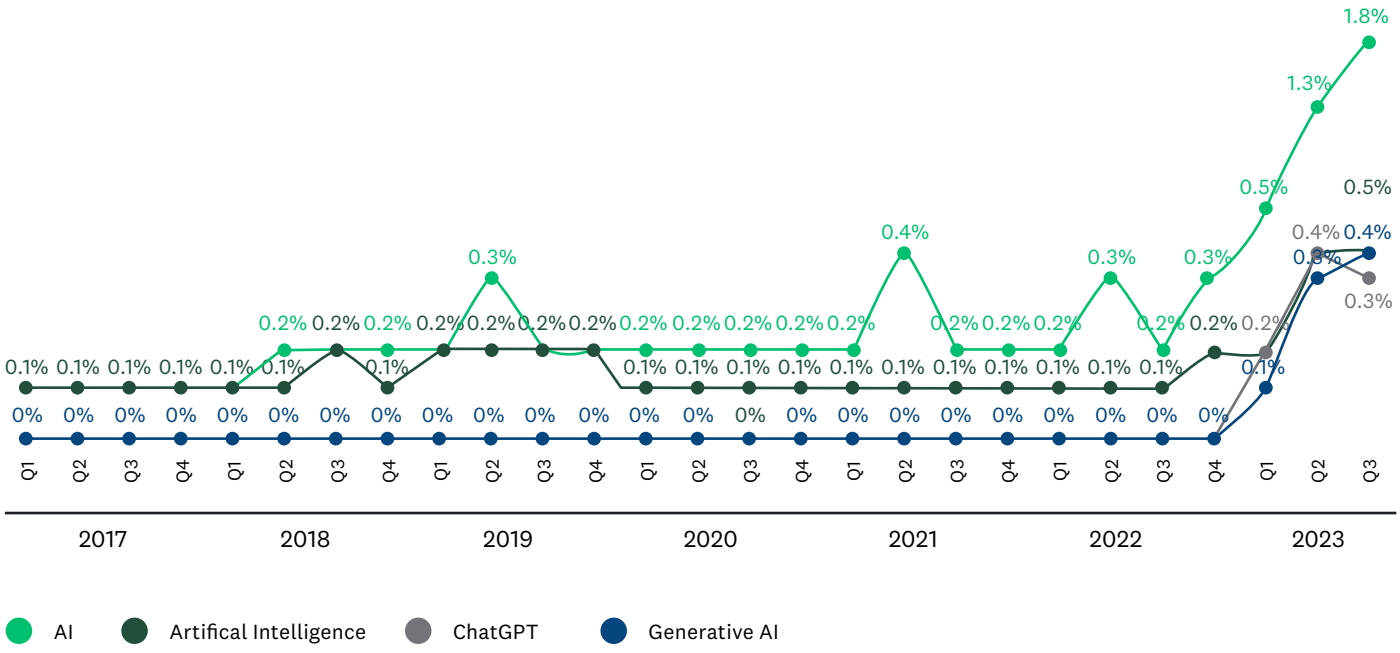
AI-related terms in surveys experienced a 4x increase in 2023

What drove the growth? The catalyst seems to be the introduction of OpenAI's chatbot, ChatGPT, which launched in September 2022. In the chart below, we can see an upswing in the past year that coincides with the introduction of a commercially available, open source AI that can be accessed via apps.



Surveys containing “AI” surge in 2023

“AI”, “artificial intelligence”, “ChatGPT”, and “generative AI” all see increased mentions within surveys starting in 2023



Along with the introduction of ChatGPT came the recognition that AI had arrived. Early users experimenting with the chatbot posted images and artwork, music mashups, and natural language answers to questions on social media, giving it instant visibility. Companies made a point of highlighting how AI is embedded in many of the systems people use every day. Whether you’re optimistic about the potential or fear an AI takeover, there is no denying that the impact of AI will be felt by all.

The increase in AI mentions reflects our users’ curiosity about this hot topic and their desire to be prepared and informed. It also signals how organizations are striving to understand AI’s potential and impact.

Survey mentions of specific AI terms surge

The theory that ChatGPT was the driver for the explosion of AI survey mentions was supported by the terms most frequently used. In our study, we included the following list of AI-related terms:

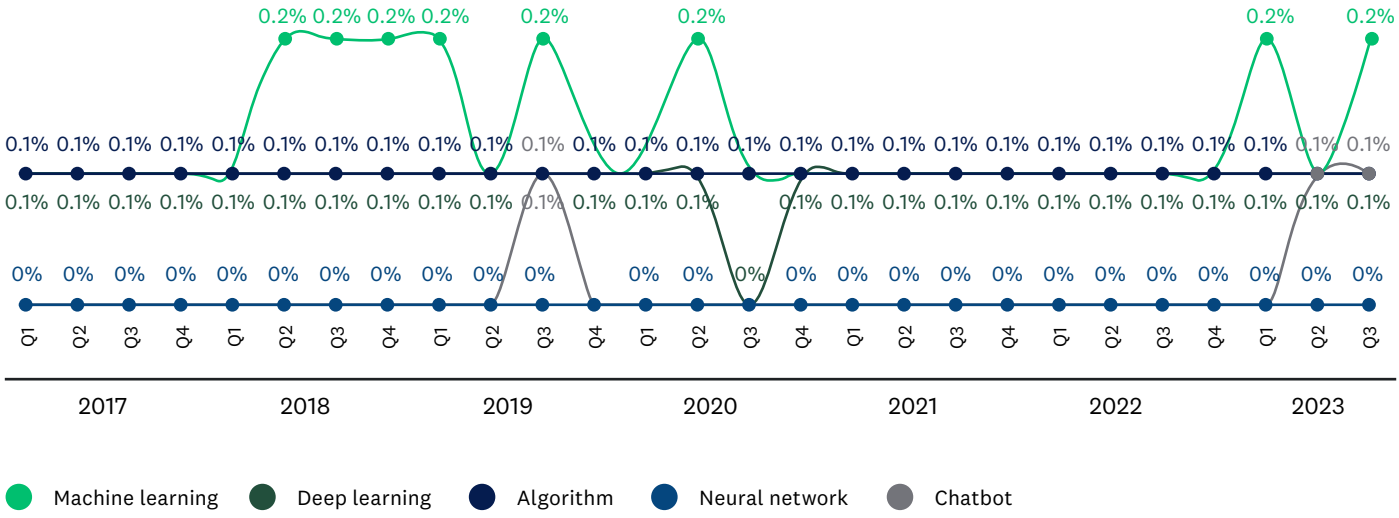
- AI
- Algorithm
- Artificial intelligence
- Generative AI
- ChatGPT
- Neural network
- Machine learning
- Chatbot
- Deep learning

Not all AI terms experienced the same lift from the introduction of ChatGPT. Mentions of “AI” grew the most, increasing by nearly 10x, from 0.2% in previous years, to 1.8% in Q3 of 2023.

Terms like “artificial intelligence” and “generative AI” saw minor increases in survey mentions, reaching around half a percent by October 2023 from nearly no mentions in prior years. More technical terms, such as “machine learning,” “deep learning,” “algorithm,” “neural network,” and “chatbot,” saw no change from previous years.

More technical AI terms see no change

“Machine learning”, “deep learning”, “algorithm”, “neural network”, and “chatbot” see little to no change in mentions within surveys


0.2% 0.2% 0.2% 0.2% 0.2% 0.2% 0.2% 0.2% 0.2%
0.1% 0.1% 0.1%

CHAPTER 2

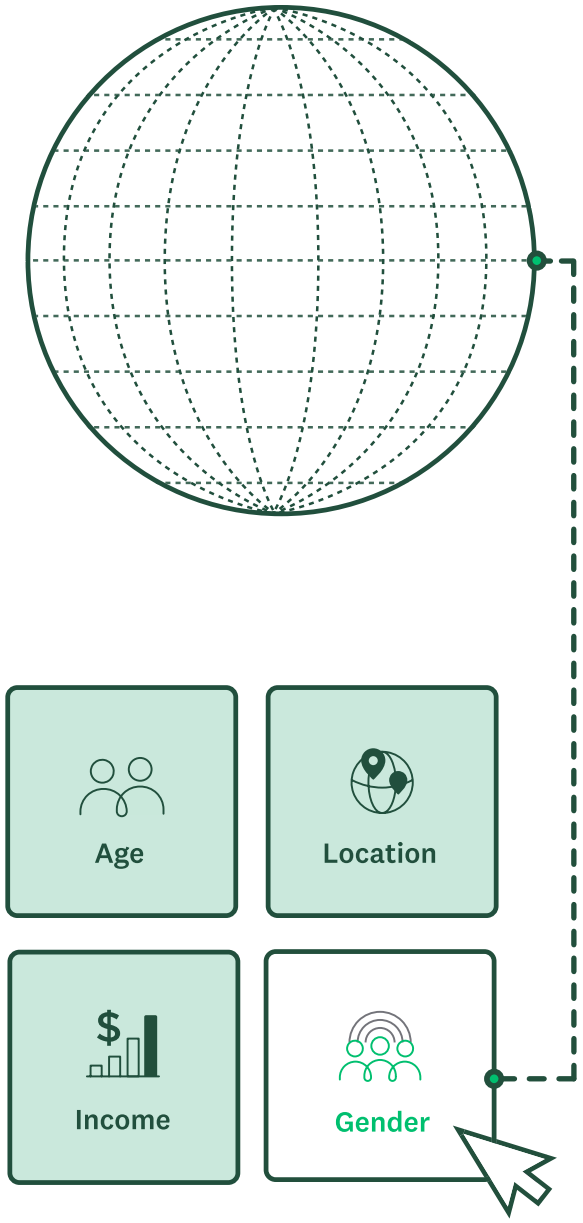
Gender around the world

Gender questions are one of the most frequently used demographic questions on our platform, acting as a filter to understanding gender differences in survey responses. Dividing a target audience into two buckets—male and female—has traditionally been a standard screening question for surveys.

However, gender questions and answers often reflect what's happening in the world. In 2022, 1.6% of adults in the US identified as nonbinary or transgender. This is even higher among adults under age 30; about 5%, or 1 in 20 young adults, identified as nonbinary. Organizations have recognized these shifts and are taking action to add more gender answer options to their studies.

The number of surveys that are gender inclusive has grown dramatically in the past decade. In 2012, between 9% and 22% of surveys sent on our platform included more than two gender answer options, depending on the country we reviewed.

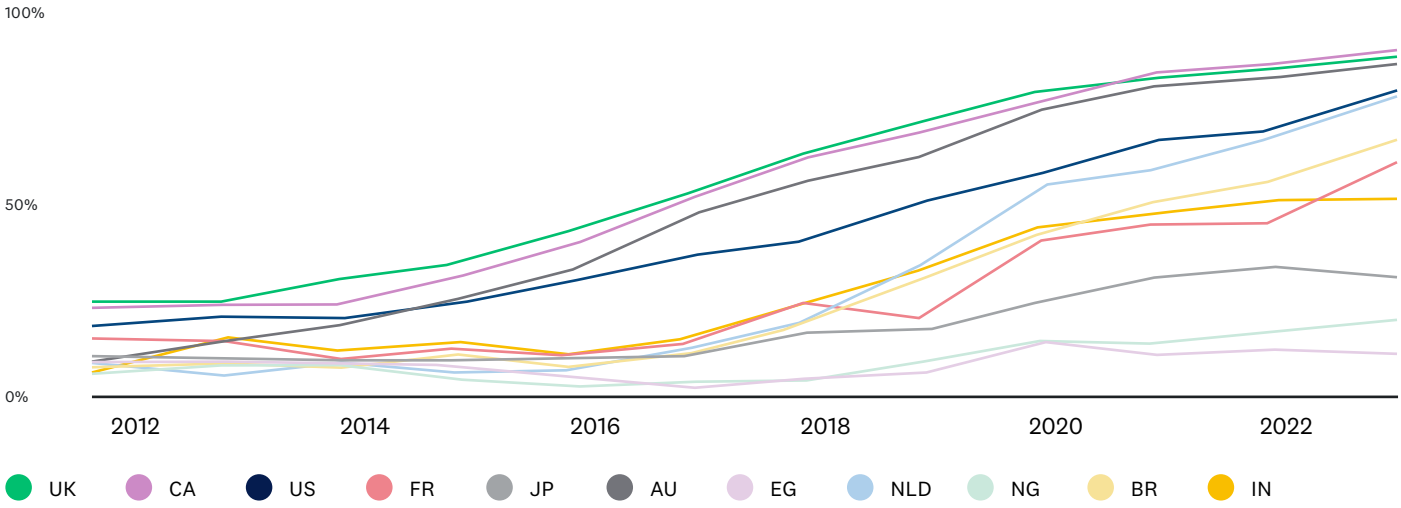
Today, that number is well above 50% for most of the countries we reviewed, and in several countries, 8 out of 10 of the surveys sent included more than two gender answer options. All of the countries we reviewed, with the exception of Egypt, Japan, and Nigeria, have seen substantial growth in surveys with more than two gender answer options over the past decade.



Most countries continue to make progress in gender inclusion

The adoption of nonbinary gender options within surveys in India, Japan, Nigeria, and Egypt has stalled in recent years

Percent of surveys with 3 or more gender options (among surveys that contain a gender question)



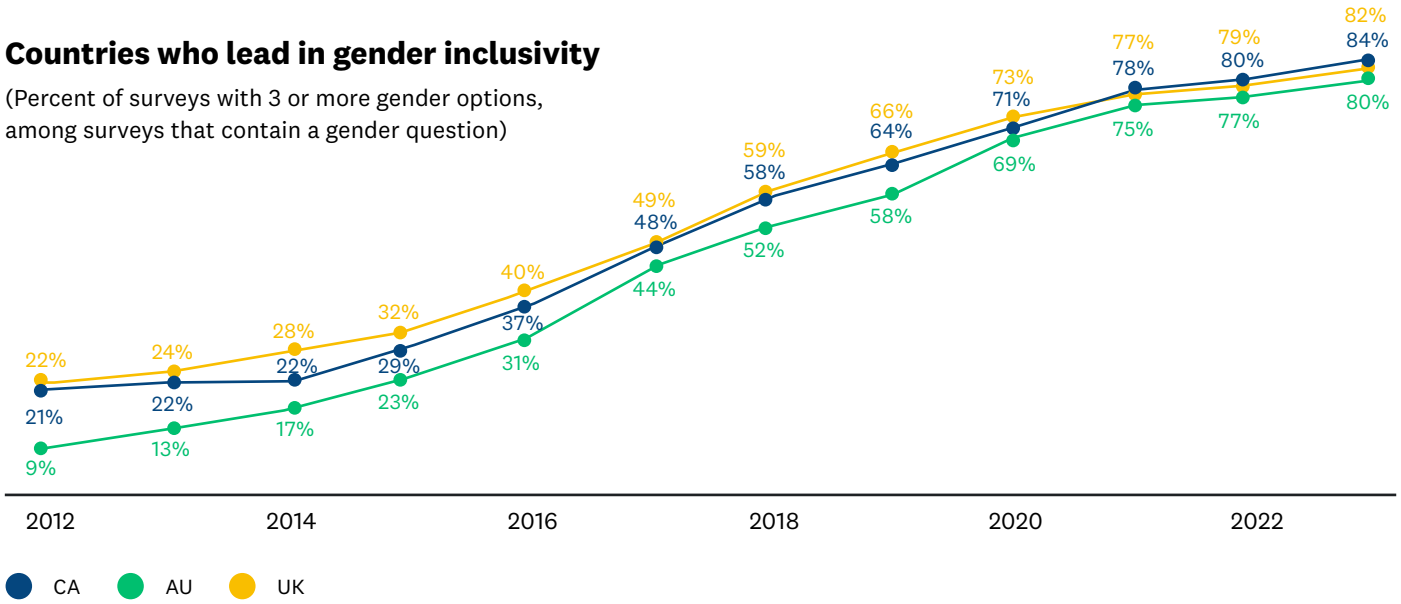
As we mentioned above, in the US, almost 3 out of 4 (73%) of the surveys sent from our platform that contain a gender question include three or more gender answer options—up from 64% in 2022.

Canada, the UK, and Australia lead in nonbinary gender inclusion

Each country sees at least 80% of surveys contain 3 or more gender options when asking about gender

Countries who lead in gender inclusivity

(Percent of surveys with 3 or more gender options, among surveys that contain a gender question)



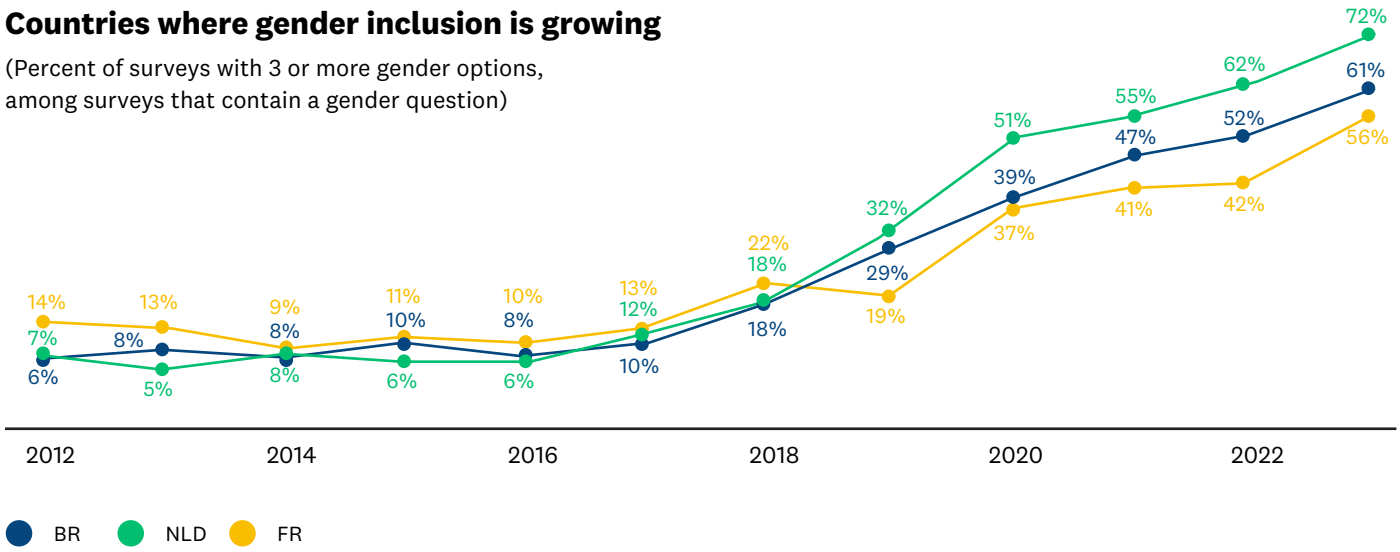
Canada, the UK, and Australia have even higher levels of nonbinary gender-inclusive answers in surveys—84% for CA, 82% for the UK, 80% for Australia.

Brazil, the Netherlands, and France see the largest increase in nonbinary gender inclusion in 2023

Each country sees double-digit growth in the percent of surveys with 3 or more gender options when asking about gender

Countries where gender inclusion is growing

(Percent of surveys with 3 or more gender options, among surveys that contain a gender question)

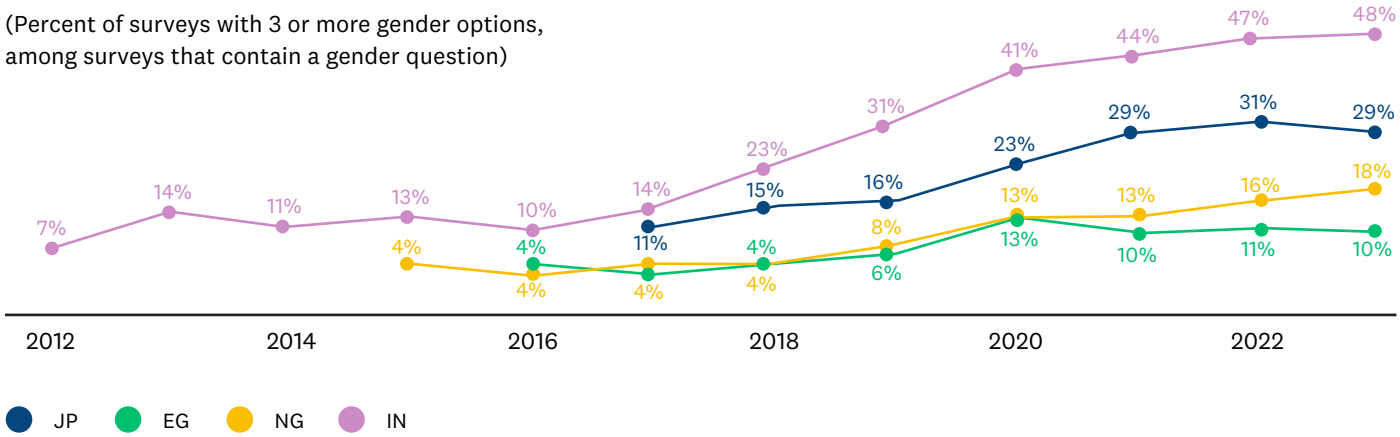


In Brazil, gender-inclusive answers increased 9 points, reaching 61% in 2023 from 52% in 2022. The Netherlands saw gender-inclusive answers increase 10 points, from 62% in 2022 to 72% in 2023.

Since 2020 gender inclusion within surveys sees little to no growth in Japan, India, Nigeria, and Egypt

Countries where gender inclusion has stagnated

(Percent of surveys with 3 or more gender options, among surveys that contain a gender question)



In some countries, however, growth in gender-inclusive surveys has stalled in recent years.

- Japan's gender-inclusive answer options remained at 29% in 2023, on par with the past two years, but up from 2019 (16%).
- In India, gender-inclusive answer options remained at 48% in 2023, equal to the previous year (47%), but still more than double 2018 (23%).
- Nigeria and Egypt trail all other countries we reviewed, with gender-inclusive answer options at 18% and 10%, respectively, in 2023.

Gender terms shift with societal changes

From "nonbinary" to "transgender," "other" to "prefer not to say," surveys can include any number of options as gender answers. Over time these terms have changed, reflecting more current thinking around transgender individuals.

In 2012, "other" and "transgender" were the most frequently used nonbinary gender answer options; particularly in the US, Canada, and Australia—the leading countries for inclusive answer options. Today, more specific terms have emerged and have overtaken "other."

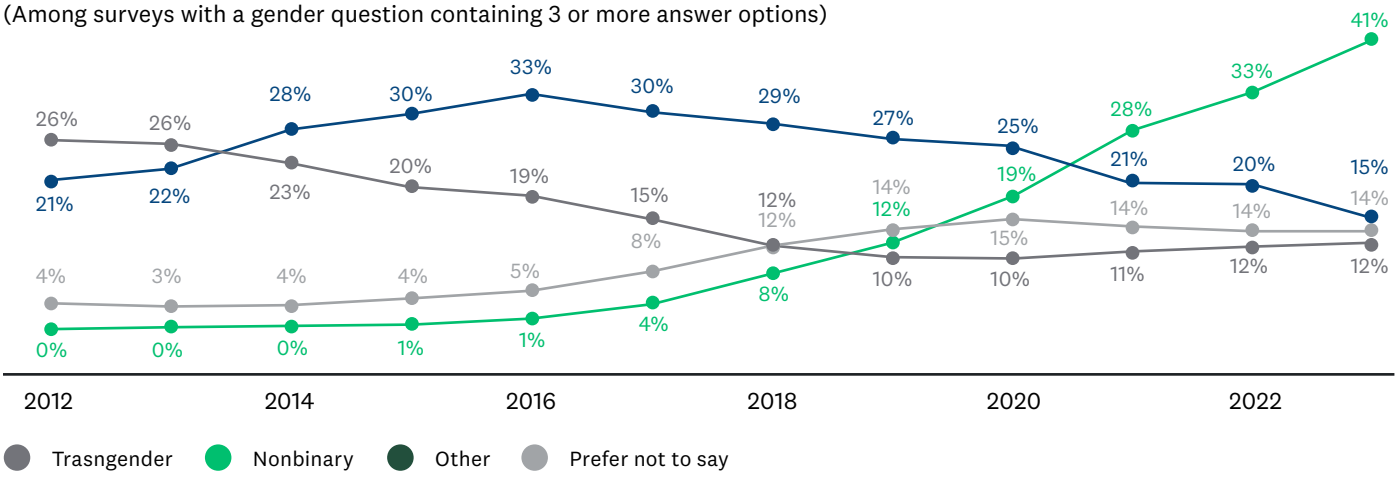
In the US, 41% of surveys use the term "nonbinary" as an answer option, which is nearly triple that of "other." The use of "other" continues its decline to 15%, after peaking at 33% in 2016. "Prefer not to say" comes in at 14%, and "transgender" at 12%.

Nonbinary usage continues to rise in the US

"Other" also continues to decline, while the usage of "transgender" and "prefer not to say" remains stable

Gender answer options (US)

(Among surveys with a gender question containing 3 or more answer options)



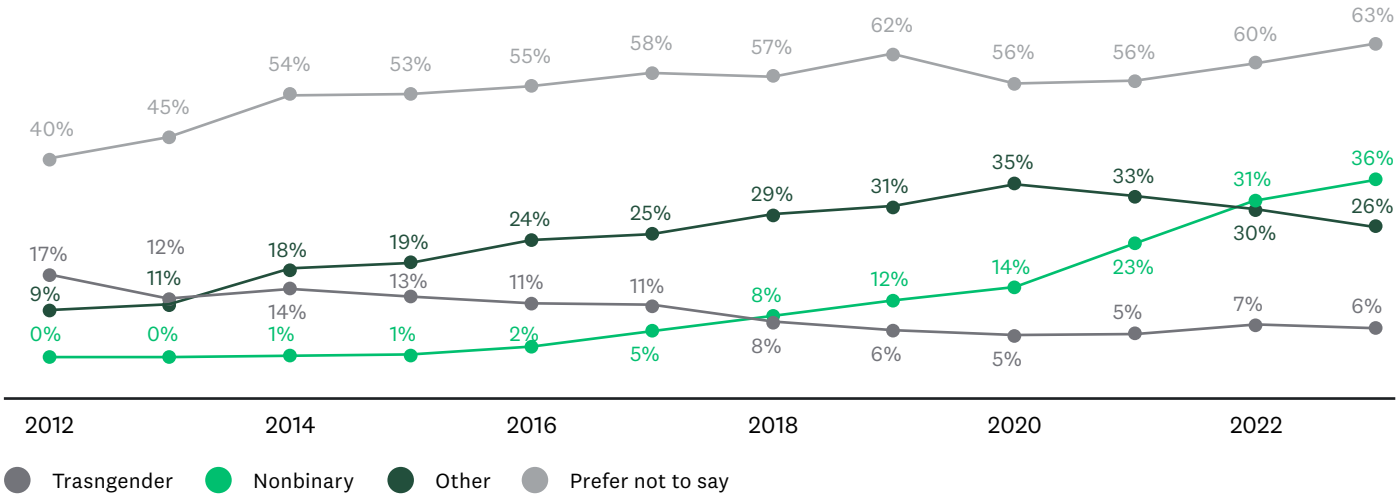
In the UK, “prefer not to say” remains the top answer option at 63%, while “nonbinary” has overtaken “other” as the second-most popular option for surveys with three or more gender answer choices. Use of “nonbinary” increased to 36% in 2023 while “other” declined to 26% in the same period.

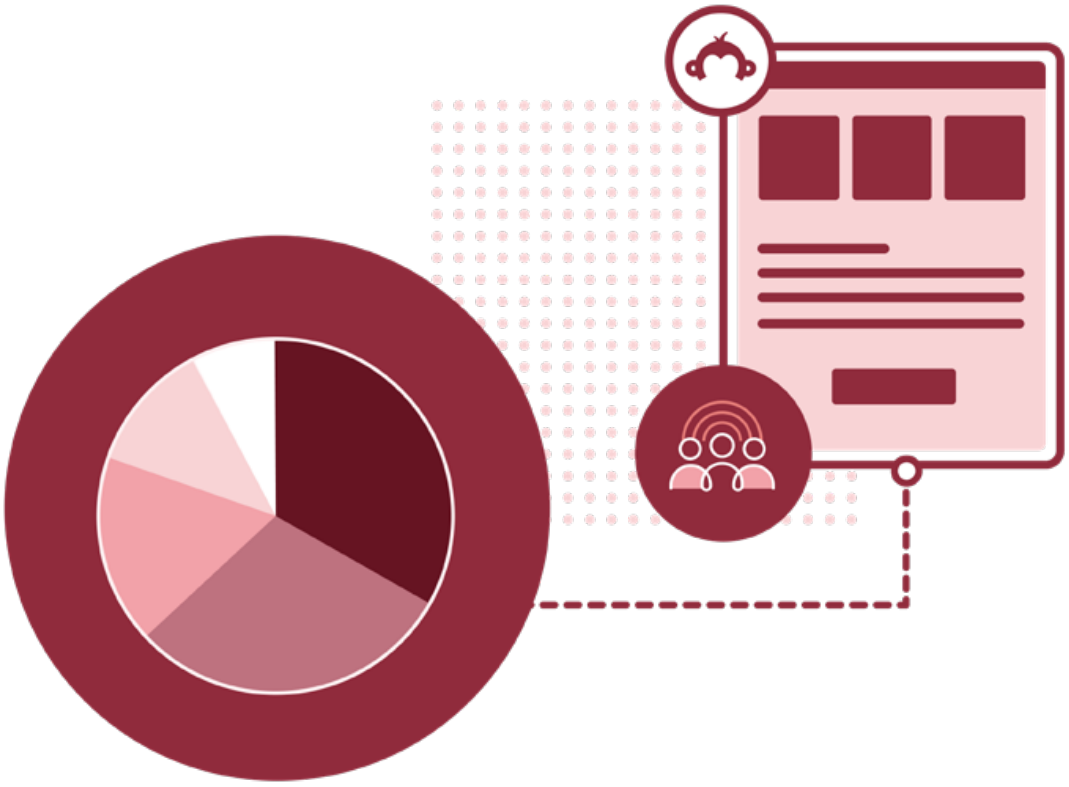
“Nonbinary” overtakes “other” in usage in the UK

While “prefer not to say” remains the most used option among nonbinary gender options, “nonbinary” continues its steady climb

Gender answer options (UK)

(Among surveys with a gender question containing 3 or more answer options)





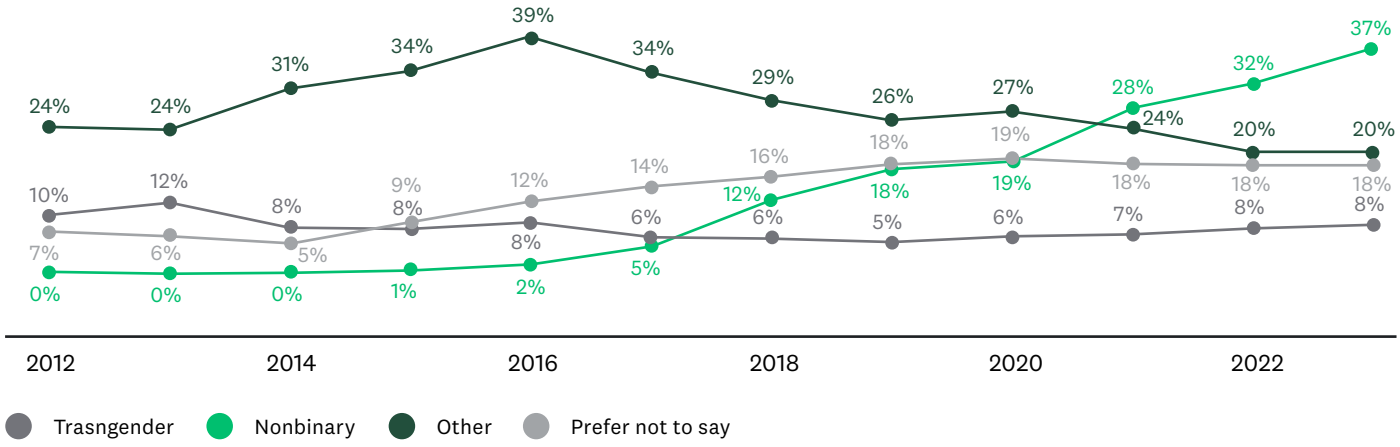
Similar to the US, Canada also saw “nonbinary” grow to become the leading answer option for gender-inclusive answer options, with usage at 37% nearly double that of “other” (20%) and “prefer not to say.”

“Nonbinary” continues to rise in Canada

“Nonbinary” as an answer option sees nearly 2x the usage of “other” and “prefer not the say”

Gender answer options (CA)

(Among surveys with a gender question containing 3 or more answer options)





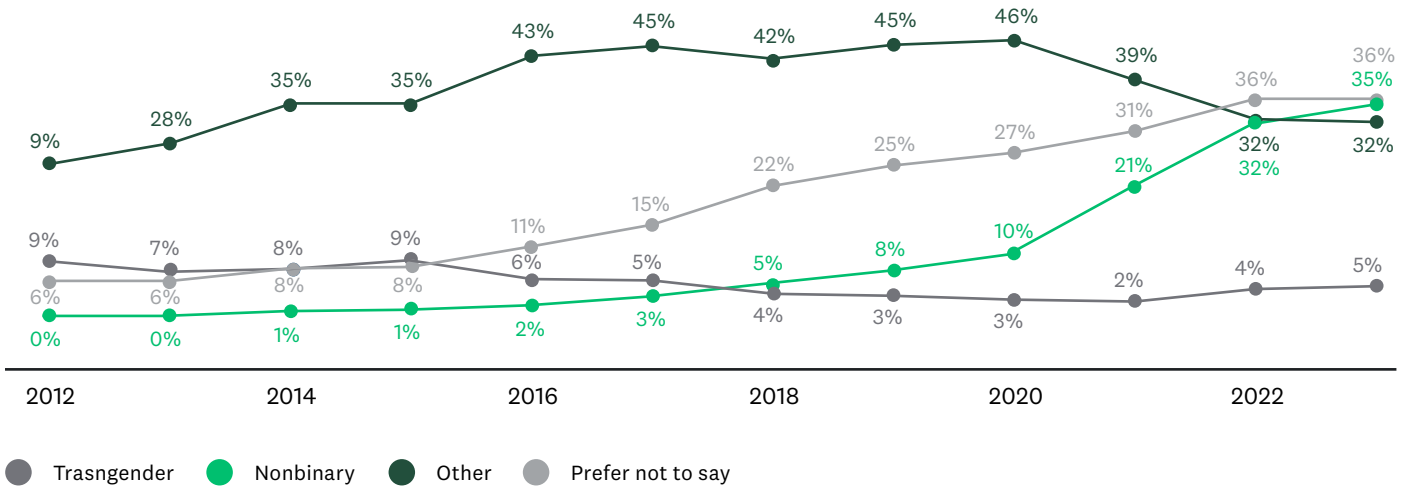
And in Australia, the use of “nonbinary” more than tripled since 2020, growing from 10% to 35% in 2023. “Prefer not to say” remains a leading answer option, while “other” continued to decline from 39% in 2021 to 32% in 2023.

Usage of “nonbinary” triples over the last 3 years in Australia

“Nonbinary” as an answer option among gender questions increases from 10% in 2020 to 35% in 2023, surpassing “other” (32%) and catching up with “prefer not to say”

Gender answer options (AU)

(Among surveys with a gender question containing 3 or more answer options)



Takeaways

Embrace gender inclusion in surveys

The growth in the number of gender answer options on a global basis mirrors the trend towards more inclusion in society. A handful of countries are setting the pace for the rest of the world, specifically the UK, Canada, Australia, and the US.

Include three or more gender answer options

The term “nonbinary” is overtaking “other” as the most commonly used third answer option, potentially indicating that people are becoming more comfortable with current categories and nomenclature.

CHAPTER 3

Engaging with employees, customers, and mobile users

The kind of surveys businesses send and how users respond were two areas that we thought were worth exploring. From CX professionals to marketers and HR pros, the surveys that are most frequently used provide insights into what companies, and these teams in particular, care about, especially when viewed over time.

In the data collected on our platform, we saw evidence of an ongoing shift to the use of mobile devices over desktop, with the number of mobile responses continuing to grow, and in most cases, surpass non-mobile responses. In the US, which has stubbornly clung to non-mobile usage, surveys are following the rest of the world in moving to a mobile-first existence.

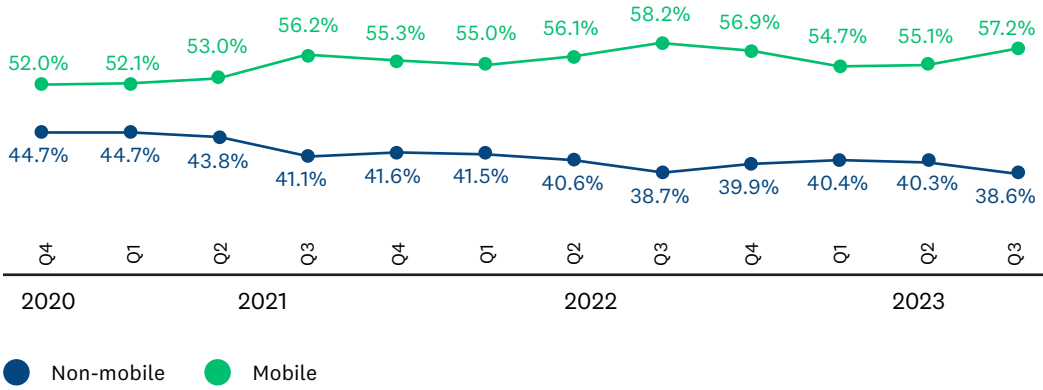
Growth of mobile

Two big stats stood out to us in terms of mobile usage. First, the gap between mobile survey-taking has widened on a global basis, growing from 7.3% in 2020 to 18.6% in 2023.



Percent of responses collected from mobile vs. non-mobile

Among global



Mobile vs. non-mobile gap	
Q4 '20	+7.3 points
Q3 '23	+18.6 points

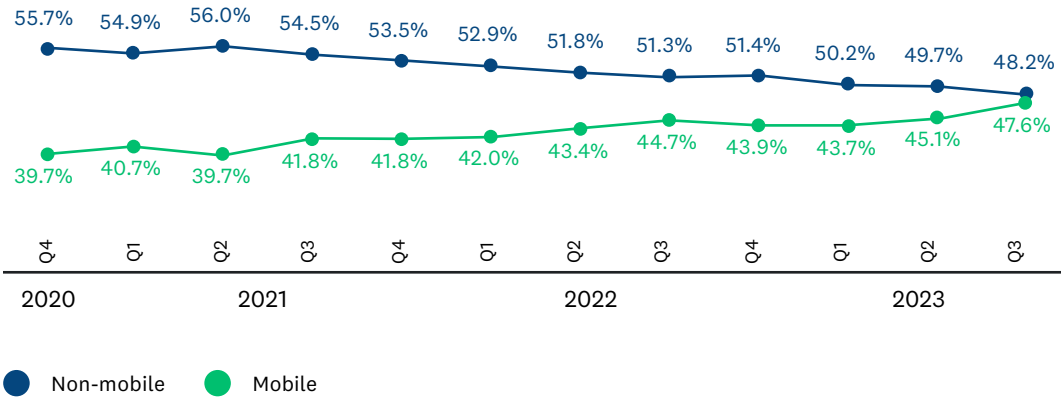
Less than 4 in 10 survey responses were submitted on non-mobile devices in 2023

However, while the gap between mobile and non-mobile devices has widened globally over the last three years, mobile growth shows signs of slowing. In 2023, 55.6% of survey responses globally were taken on a mobile device, on par with 56% the previous year.

US mobile survey responses have finally reached parity with non-mobile responses. In fact, the gap between mobile and non-mobile responses shrunk from 16% in Q4 2020 to 0.6% in Q3 2023.

Percent of responses collected from mobile vs. non-mobile

Among US



Mobile vs. non-mobile gap	
Q4 '20	-16.1 points
Q3 '23	-0.6 points

Survey templates provide a window into business priorities

SurveyMonkey provides an extensive library of templates—pre-designed surveys that are purpose-built for a specific task, from customer satisfaction to event feedback or market research. These templates are written by experts and designed to help customers collect the most accurate information from their survey efforts.

We tracked the use of our templates over the past year to understand what our customers were curious about. Here's a sampling of our most-used templates and how their popularity ties into what's top of mind for companies today.

The top survey template used by HR pros was Employee engagement. This survey measures engagement, motivation and employees' feelings about career development, training, and advancement. Meeting feedback followed close behind, highlighting the importance of collaboration in the workplace, meeting effectiveness, and how comfortable employees feel in voicing their opinions, especially when many might be remote.

For CX pros, the top template is the Customer satisfaction survey, which measures loyalty and taps into key metrics of the customer experience, including overall satisfaction with products and services. Net Promoter Score® (NPS®) is the second-most used survey template for CX pros.

Amongst marketers, Professional event feedback was the #3 template, behind the Name testing template at #2, and the top form for marketers—NPS.

Event registration was the top form used in 2023, overall. Event RSVP was the #2 form and Conference registration #5—highlighting how companies are investing in live, in-person events and conferences.



Takeaways

Consider mobile surveys

Mobile surveys continue to increase worldwide, with US mobile usage projected to be equal to desktop usage by 2024.

Try a template

For companies, engagement is the name of the game as usage of templates focuses on connecting with employees, customers, and remote workers.

Use forms to streamline event registration and RSVPs

As in-person events increase, use of registration and RSVP forms has also soared, and top the list of the most used forms and templates, overall.

CHAPTER 4

Best practices: Timing, length, templates, & more

A well-designed and executed survey can produce amazing insights from customers, employees, or your ideal target audience. The topic, questions, and survey timing can all impact the quality of insights you uncover.

That's why survey best practices are so important; they help to ensure that the data you collect is accurate and authentic. But best practices evolve over time.

In this section, we've looked back over the past decade and put together a collection of insights that reflect survey trends, and what elements can impact the metrics you care about. We've included tips on improving response rates, completion rates, and more. Read on to learn about how you can harness these trends to improve your survey sends.



Survey length trending down

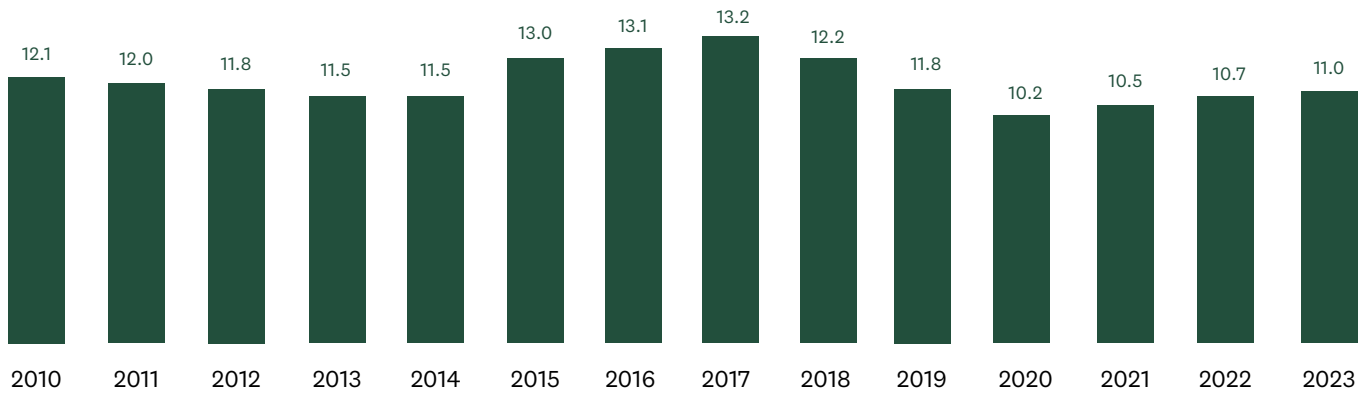
There's a lot of anecdotal beliefs about survey length—keep it under twenty questions, ten minutes or less to complete, or limit it to one question per page. You probably have your own best practices about what works. Here is data we've collected on survey trends on our platform.

"Less is more" seems to have sunk in for survey creators. Over the past 6 years, the number of questions per survey has trended down by around 15%—from 13.2 questions in 2017 to 11 questions in 2023.

Surveys are getting shorter, on average

Surveys fielded on our platform have around 11 questions in 2023, compared to 13.2 in 2017

Average number of questions in a survey by year

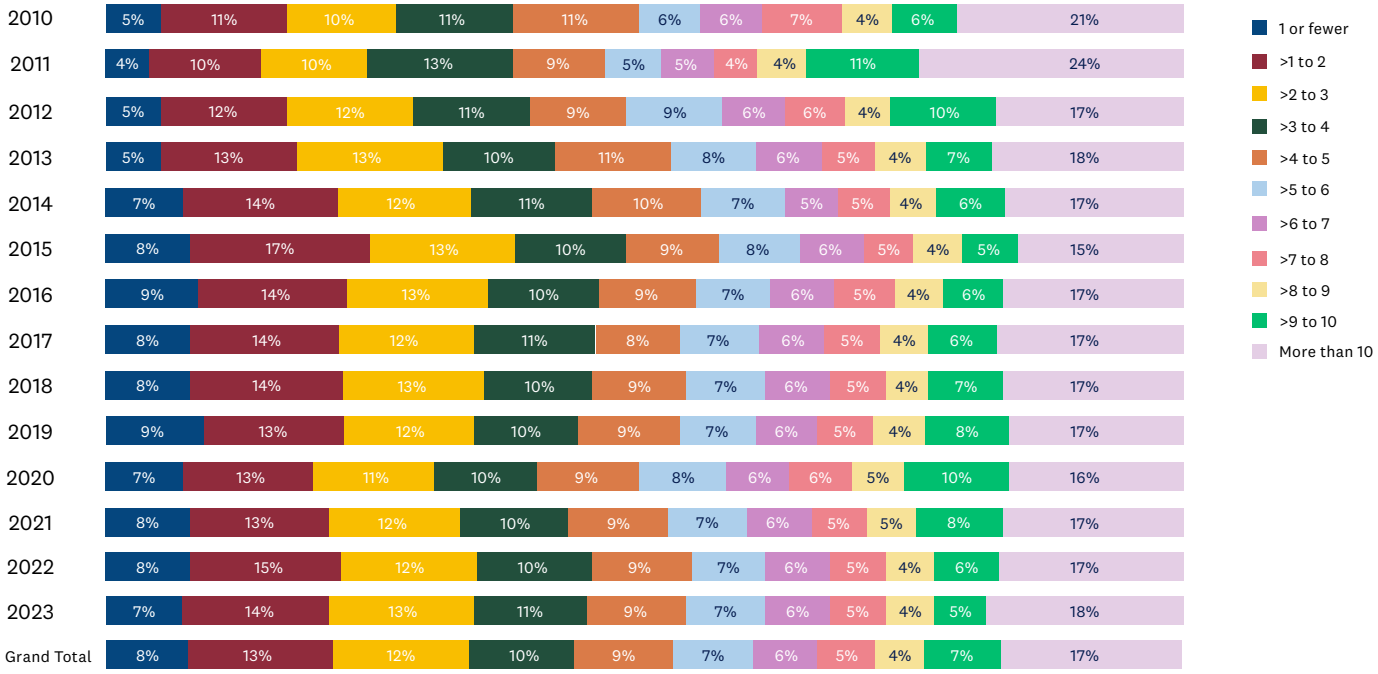


In addition, the percentage of surveys with 1 to 5 questions has increased about 10 points, while the percentage of surveys with 6 to 10 questions has declined by the same amount.

The number of questions per page has remained more stable. Slightly more than half (53%) of surveys contain five or fewer questions per page, with little change throughout the last ten years.

Keeping it brief: nearly half (53%) of all surveys have 5 questions or fewer per page, with little change over the last decade

Number of questions per page by year



53% of surveys have 5 or fewer questions per page

Optimizing completion rates

Improving survey completion rates is a worthy goal. It'll help you collect more complete data and can save you time and money if you're able to avoid resends or buying new panel respondents.

There are several things you can do to improve completion rates—from choosing the right day to send your survey to harnessing templates that are designed by professional researchers or leveraging questions that are designed to collect more reliable data.

Day of the week matters

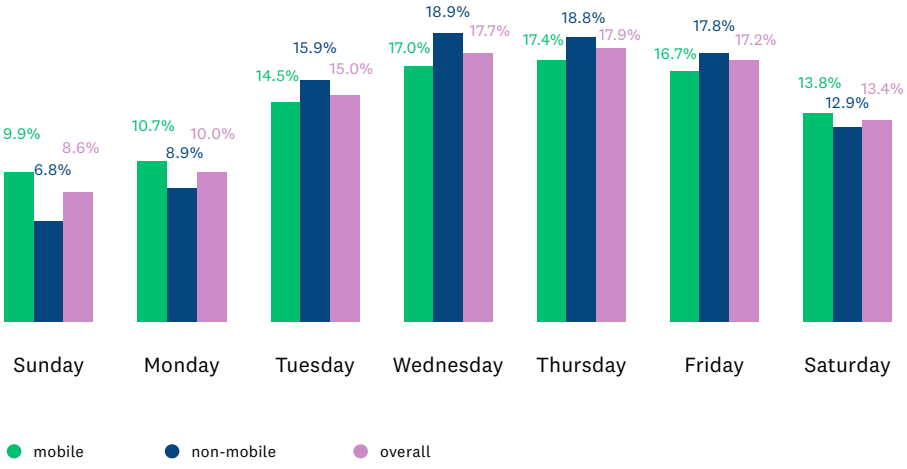
Most surveys are sent and responded to during the week. Almost 4 in 5 (78%) survey responses are submitted between Monday and Friday. Less than 1 in 4 (22%) survey responses are submitted during the weekend.

Response rates are lowest on Sunday and Monday and peak mid-week on Wednesday and Thursday.

Most surveys are taken during weekdays

Mobile devices see a greater share of responses on weekends, compared to non-mobile devices

Distribution of responses submitted by day of week



	Weekend	Weekday
Overall	22.10%	77.90%
Mobile	23.70%	76.30%
Non-mobile	19.70%	80.30%

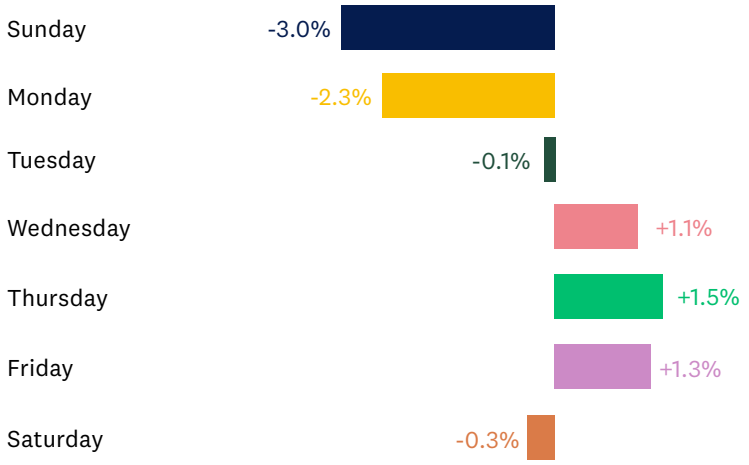
In terms of completion rates, Sunday and Monday have the lowest completion rates, while Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday have the highest. Surveys sent on a Sunday have a 3 points lower completion rate than average, followed by Mondays, which is 2 points lower. Surveys taken on Tuesdays and Saturdays have almost average completion rates, while Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday see higher-than-average completion rates.

Surveys taken on Sunday and Monday have lower completion rates than those taken later in the week

Surveys taken on Tuesday and Saturday see near-average completion rates, while those taken on Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday are more likely to be completed

Completion rate by day of week - overall

(over (+) / under (-) average completion rate)



Completion rates are slightly different on mobile—surveys taken on mobile devices are more likely to be submitted on weekends compared to those taken on non-mobile devices (24% vs. 20%).

Templates deliver higher completion rates

We build our expertise into our templates, which are designed internally by our survey experts with best practices in mind.

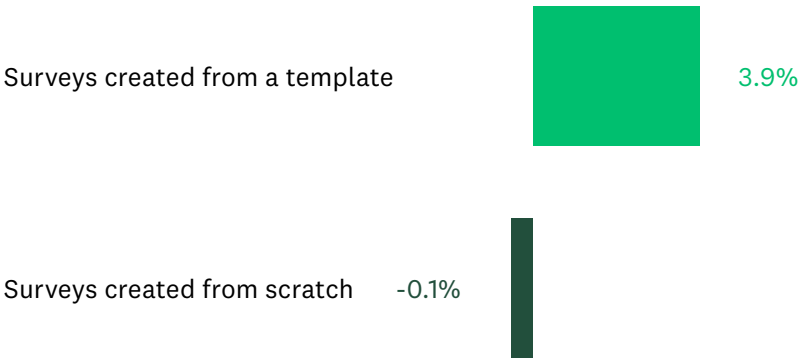
On our platform, we saw template usage double in 2023. Why? Not only can templates save time, they can also deliver real benefits. The data we collected shows that using templates delivers higher completion rates. In fact, surveys based on a template delivered a 4 point boost in completion rates compared to a survey created from scratch.

Surveys created from a template see higher completion rates

Surveys that are based off of templates see completion rates four percentage points higher than surveys created from scratch

Completion rate by template usage

(over(+) / under (-) point average completion rate)



SurveyMonkey Question Bank can give your surveys a lift

Question banks are another hidden gem for our survey users. At SurveyMonkey, the Question Bank is a library containing hundreds of questions that can be added to a survey in seconds. These questions are written and certified by our survey methodologists and incorporate best practices that will elevate your survey game.

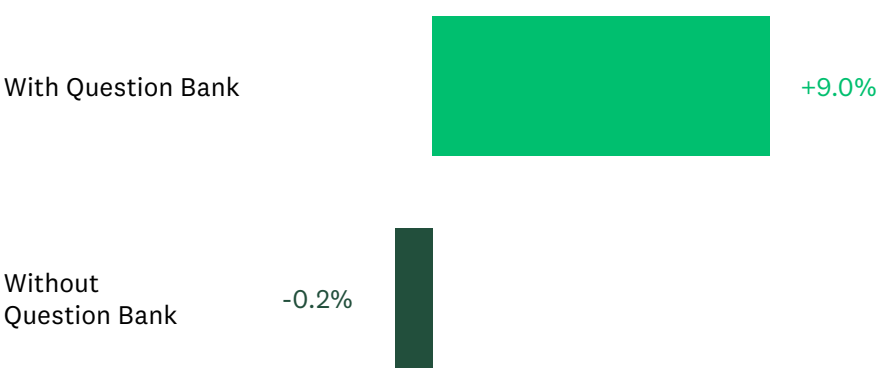
Using the Question Bank can deliver real benefits. On our platform, surveys that used the question bank saw a 9 point increase in completion rates compared to surveys that don't use the question bank.

Surveys that use the SurveyMonkey Question Bank see higher completion rates

Surveys that are based off of templates see completion rates four percentage points higher than surveys created from scratch

Completion rate by Question Bank usage

(over (+) / under (-) point average completion rate)



Takeaways

Send your surveys mid week

Survey response submissions are higher during the week—with four in five survey submissions happening Monday through Friday. Survey completion rates are highest on Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday and lowest on Sunday and Monday.

Consider optimizing your surveys for mobile

Mobile users are more inclined to take a survey on a weekend than non-mobile users, but still have higher completion rates mid-week.

Take advantage of pre-designed templates and questions

Use of survey templates grew by 2x between 2022 and 2023—and templates deliver 4 points higher completion rates. Plus, using the Question Bank increases completion rates by 9 points.

CHEAT SHEET

How to put these insights to work

It's always fascinating to see how the world is evolving by getting a look into what others are working on. But it's more than just intriguing; there are way to harness the data we collected and get value out of our insights.

Here are some ways to use the data from this study for yourself.

Embrace gender inclusion

Create more accurate profiles of your respondents by including three or four gender answer options in your surveys. Make "nonbinary" a choice, plus consider offering a "fill in the blank" option where respondents can self-describe. Check out our survey templates, designed to improve gender inclusivity.

- Gender inclusivity at work
- Gender in the workplace template
- More on gender and research trends

Consider the impact of AI

As AI moves mainstream, the number of AI mentions in surveys has quadrupled over the last year. Consider adding AI questions to your surveys to better understand how you can address customer perceptions—and expectations. Harness AI features in your surveys to improve the quality of your data and uncover insights and trends you might have missed.

- Try SurveyMonkey Build with AI
- Read our recent AI research
- More on Build with AI latest developments

Get better results by harnessing best practices

Using our templates and Question Bank puts the power of our survey expertise in your hands. You'll save time and collect more reliable data, plus see higher completion rates. You should also consider optimizing your surveys for mobile; in many places in the world, mobile surveys see higher completion rates.

- Templates and more
- How and why to create a mobile-centric survey
- Mobile optimization for surveys: a how-to guide

APPENDIX

Methodology

We leveraged SurveyMonkey's 20+ years of being one of the world's most popular feedback platforms and combine it with leading-edge best practices to deliver insights into survey trends that no other feedback company can offer. Starting in 2022, our annual State of Surveys report spotlights top survey trends, including topics such as template usage, mobile surveys, and gender.

Mobile data

We compared the percentage of survey responses submitted on the SurveyMonkey platform via mobile device or desktop/pc. Data for device usage was collected between November 2020 and September 2023, with tablet/other device usage included but not shown. Device usage is calculated by dividing the number of survey responses taken on a specific device by the total number of responses submitted on the SurveyMonkey platform.

Template data

We created a ranking of the top US templates based on the number of deployments and category. Only templates shown on SurveyMonkey.com are included in rankings. Data was collected from January 2023 to September 2023.

Template usage

We queried the total number of surveys deployed and based off of a template (including Build It For Me, forms, etc.), as well as the total number of surveys deployed. Completion rates are calculated by dividing the number of surveys completed by the number of surveys started, among surveys taken on the SurveyMonkey platform.

For the day of the week stats, we compared the percentage of survey responses submitted on the SurveyMonkey platform by each day of the week, with additional cuts by device type (mobile vs. desktop/pc). Completion rates are calculated by the total number of surveys completed by the total number of surveys started on the given day of week, among surveys taken on the SurveyMonkey platform.

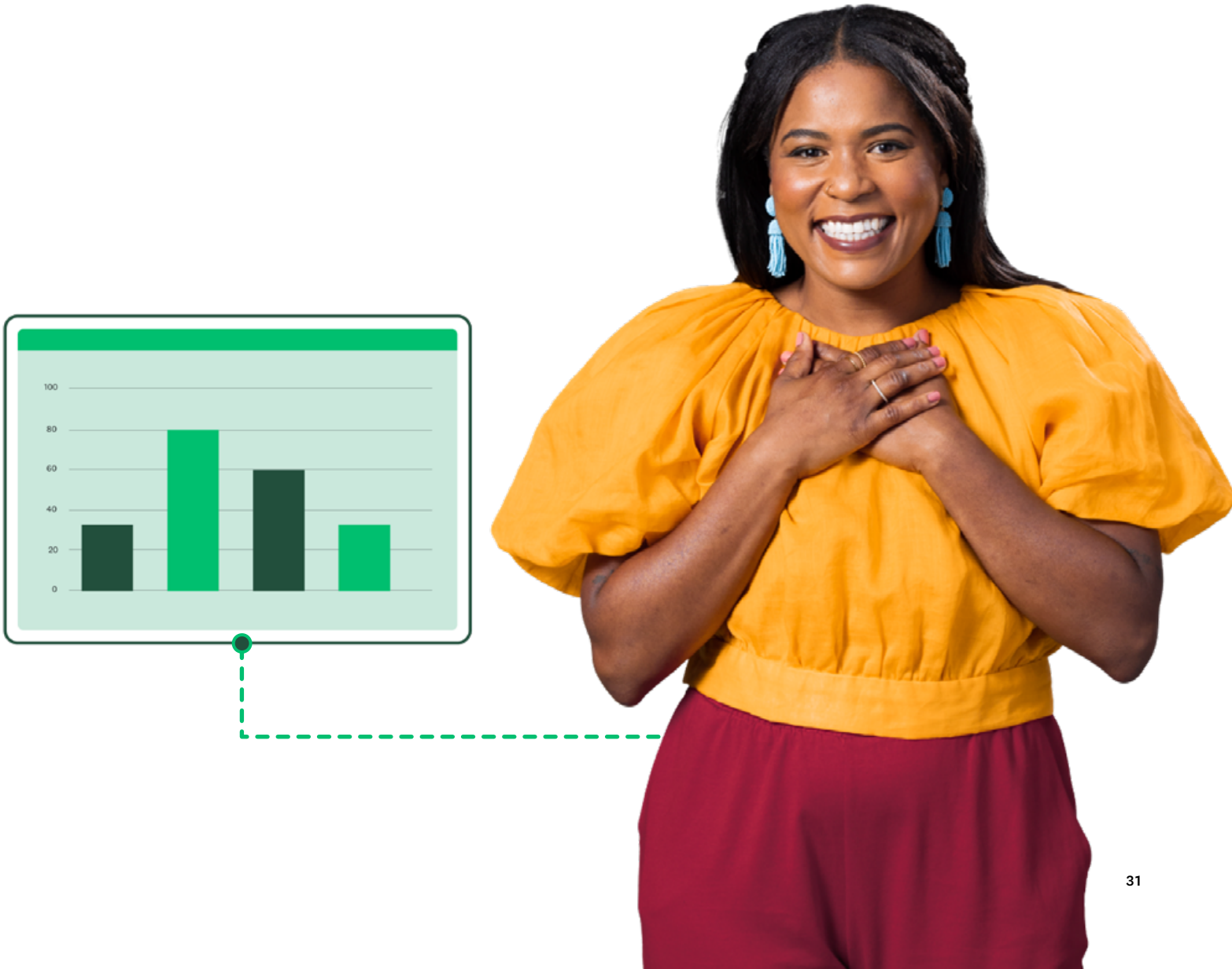
AI data

We queried the total number of surveys deployed in the US with question titles or answer options that contained AI-related keywords, including: “Machine learning,” “Deep learning,” Algorithm,” “Neural network,” “Chatbot,” “AI,” “Artificial intelligence,” “ChatGPT,” or “Generative AI.”

This data was collected between January 2020 and September 2023. Percentages in the chart are calculated by dividing the number of surveys with questions containing any AI-related keywords by the total number of surveys deployed on the SurveyMonkey platform.

Gender data

We queried the total number of deployed surveys containing a gender question that contains specific criteria (e.g. number of answer options, keywords) by the total number of surveys containing a gender question. A question is considered a gender question if it contains the words “male,” “female,” “woman,” or “man” as answer options.



SurveyMonkey



Get the insights you need to ask, listen, and act.

Find out how to harness survey findings to inform decisions in your organization

Get Started